AI PRODUCT MANAGEMENT 2 · DETAILED COURSE

Product Requirements and Documentation

Writing clear requirements and documents that engineers can build from and teams can trace, test and release.

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CHAPTER 05

Product Requirements and Documentation

Writing clear requirements and documents that engineers can build from and teams can trace, test and release.

Product Requirement Document (PRD)

The shared document describing the problem, users, goals, scope, requirements, metrics and launch plan.

A PRD describes the problem, target users, goals, scope, requirements, success metrics and launch plan. It is a shared reference for teams, not a contract. Keep it short and link to research and designs rather than copying them in.

Business Requirement Document (BRD)

Business-level needs, objectives, scope and constraints, usually for stakeholders and sponsors.

A BRD captures business needs, objectives, scope and constraints, usually for sponsors and finance. It answers why the business should invest. The PRD then explains what the product will do to deliver that business case.

Functional Requirements

What the system must do: behaviours and features.

Functional requirements describe what the system must do, such as "a user can reset a password by email". Write each one so it can be tested. Vague phrases such as "easy to use" are not functional requirements.

Non-Functional Requirements

How well it must do it: performance, security, reliability, scalability and compliance.

These describe how well the system must perform: response time, availability, security, scalability and compliance. Quantify them, for example "99.9% uptime per month" or "search returns in under 300 ms for 95% of queries".

Technical Requirements

Constraints and needs for architecture, integrations, data, platforms and infrastructure.

Technical requirements cover architecture, integrations, data formats, platforms and infrastructure. Engineers should review them early, because they often change cost and timeline. Include constraints such as data residency rules.

Product Specifications

Detailed descriptions of behaviour, rules, data and interfaces sufficient for build and test.

Specifications describe behaviour, rules, data and interfaces in enough detail to build and test the feature. Include edge cases, validation rules and examples. A good spec reduces questions during development.

Epics, Features and User Stories

Epics are large goals, features are deliverable capabilities, stories are small user-centred slices a team can finish in a sprint.

An epic is a large goal, a feature is a deliverable capability, and a user story is a small, user-centred slice that fits in one sprint. Example: "Faster payouts" as an epic, "Instant payout request" as a feature, and "As a seller, I can request a payout from my dashboard" as a story.

User Story Mapping

Arranging stories along the user journey to see the whole experience and slice releases.

Story mapping arranges stories along the user journey, with the most important path at the top. Slice releases horizontally so each release delivers a usable end-to-end path rather than half of many features.

Acceptance Criteria

Specific, testable conditions that must be true for a story to be accepted, often in Given/When/Then form.

Acceptance criteria are specific, testable conditions a story must meet. The Given/When/Then format is common: given a verified account, when the user requests a payout above the limit, then the system shows the limit message.

Definition of Ready

The checklist a story must meet before the team starts it, such as clear value, criteria and dependencies.

The checklist a story must meet before the team starts work: clear value, acceptance criteria, dependencies identified and design available. It prevents half-understood work entering a sprint.

Definition of Done

The shared quality bar every item must meet to count as finished: tested, reviewed, documented, deployable.

The shared quality bar every item must meet: tested, reviewed, documented, monitored and deployable. Without it, items are called done before they are safe to release.

Use Cases

Step-by-step descriptions of how an actor achieves a goal with the system, including alternatives.

A use case describes how an actor achieves a goal with the system, including alternative paths and failures. Use cases are useful for complex workflows such as loan approval, where many roles and rules interact.

Edge Cases

Rare or extreme inputs and states that can break flows, found by asking what happens when things are empty, huge, slow or invalid.

Edge cases are rare or extreme inputs and states, such as an empty cart, a very large file or a timeout during payment. Ask what happens when inputs are empty, huge, slow or invalid. Many production bugs live in these cases.

Error Scenarios

How the product behaves when things fail, with clear messages, recovery paths and logging.

Error scenarios describe how the product behaves when something fails, including the message shown, the recovery path and what is logged. Good error handling tells the user what to do next.

Product Backlog Creation

A prioritised list of everything that might be built, each item with value and clear description.

The backlog is a prioritised list of everything that might be built. Each item needs a clear description and an expected value. Keep the backlog honest by removing items that no longer matter.

Backlog Refinement

Regularly clarifying, splitting, estimating and ordering backlog items so the next sprints are ready.

Refinement regularly clarifies, splits, estimates and orders backlog items so the next sprints are ready. Refine two to three sprints ahead. Items should be small enough to finish within one sprint.

Release Documentation

Release notes, change logs, runbooks and support guides that explain what changed and how to operate it.

Release notes, change logs, runbooks and support guides explain what changed and how to operate it. Support teams need these before launch, not after the first customer complaint.

Product Requirement Traceability

Linking each requirement to its goal, design, tests and release to prove coverage and manage change.

Traceability links each requirement to its goal, design, tests and release. It shows that every requirement is covered and helps assess the impact of a change. Use a simple table or tool, and keep it current.

Technical Documentation

Architecture notes, API docs and runbooks that let others build, integrate and maintain.

Architecture notes, API references and runbooks let others build, integrate and support the product. Keep them next to the code so they are updated with it.

Product Decision Records

Short records of decisions, options considered, reasons and consequences, so context is not lost.

A decision record notes the decision, the options considered, the reason and the expected consequences. Months later, people can see why a choice was made instead of re-arguing it.

Summary of terms

Term	Meaning
Product Requirement Document (PRD)	The shared document describing the problem, users, goals, scope, requirements, metrics and launch plan.
Business Requirement Document (BRD)	Business-level needs, objectives, scope and constraints, usually for stakeholders and sponsors.
Functional Requirements	What the system must do: behaviours and features.
Non-Functional Requirements	How well it must do it: performance, security, reliability, scalability and compliance.
Technical Requirements	Constraints and needs for architecture, integrations, data, platforms and infrastructure.
Product Specifications	Detailed descriptions of behaviour, rules, data and interfaces sufficient for build and test.
Epics, Features and User Stories	Epics are large goals, features are deliverable capabilities, stories are small user-centred slices a team can finish in a sprint.
User Story Mapping	Arranging stories along the user journey to see the whole experience and slice releases.
Acceptance Criteria	Specific, testable conditions that must be true for a story to be accepted, often in Given/When/Then form.
Definition of Ready	The checklist a story must meet before the team starts it, such as clear value, criteria and dependencies.
Definition of Done	The shared quality bar every item must meet to count as finished: tested, reviewed, documented, deployable.
Use Cases	Step-by-step descriptions of how an actor achieves a goal with the system, including alternatives.
Edge Cases	Rare or extreme inputs and states that can break flows, found by asking what happens when things are empty, huge, slow or invalid.
Error Scenarios	How the product behaves when things fail, with clear messages, recovery paths and logging.
Product Backlog Creation	A prioritised list of everything that might be built, each item with value and clear description.
Backlog Refinement	Regularly clarifying, splitting, estimating and ordering backlog items so the next sprints are ready.
Release Documentation	Release notes, change logs, runbooks and support guides that explain what changed and how to operate it.

Product Requirement Traceability	Linking each requirement to its goal, design, tests and release to prove coverage and manage change.
Technical Documentation	Architecture notes, API docs and runbooks that let others build, integrate and maintain.
Product Decision Records	Short records of decisions, options considered, reasons and consequences, so context is not lost.

Practice exercise: Write a two-page PRD with user stories, Given/When/Then acceptance criteria and three edge cases for a feature you choose.

Self-check

1. Explain Product Requirement Document (PRD) in two sentences to a non-technical stakeholder, then say what you would measure for it.
2. Explain Definition of Done in two sentences to a non-technical stakeholder, then say what you would measure for it.
3. Explain Product Decision Records in two sentences to a non-technical stakeholder, then say what you would measure for it.

Related SkillNavora material

- PRD library: Template, framing guide and 120 PRD ideas.
- AI PRD Writer: Draft a PRD with AI.
- BRD and FRD guide: Business and functional requirement documents.
- AI PM Toolkit: Templates and helpers for PM work.
- AI Tutor: Ask questions on any topic.
- Study Library: Every lesson, class and PDF by programme.

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